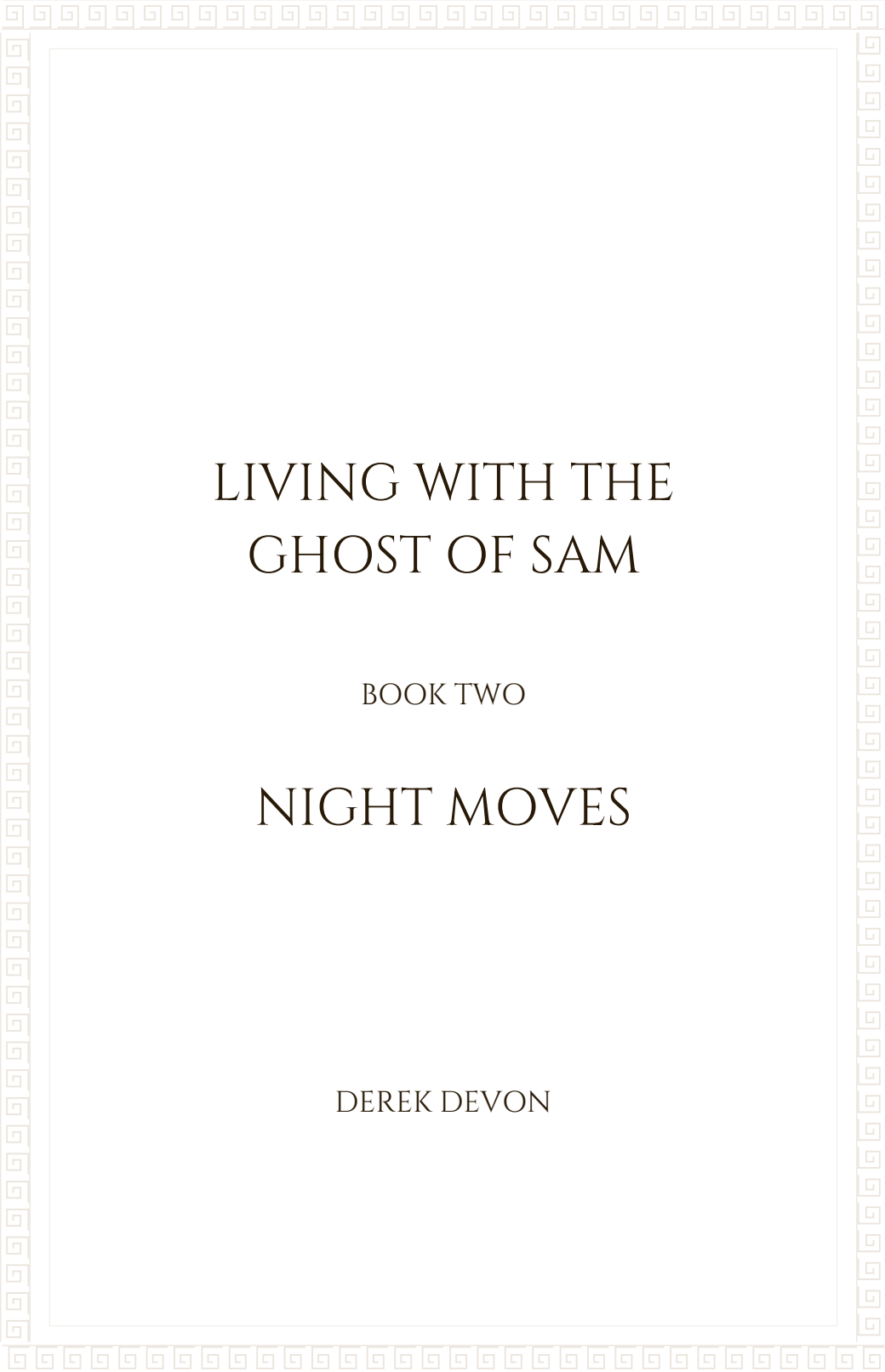




LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM

BOOK TWO

NIGHT MOVES

DEREK DEVON

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First Edition, 2026 Self-published by the author.

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To my It-Girl.

I never won her heart — wrong timing maybe, but she owned mine. She was the only true love of my life, and I never got the moment. So I did what writers do: I wrote it. She's in these pages, and in every book I've written — different names, same girl, finally getting the scenes we never had.

Some men buy sports cars. I write her into novels. My therapist says this is healthier.

I only know it puts a smile on my face every day (12757982)....

THE LIVING WITH THE GHOST OF SAM SERIES

Book One — Living With the Ghost of Sam

Book Two — Night Moves

Book Three — Two Out of Three Ain't Bad

Book Four — Last Laugh

Book Five — Digital Inheritance

Book Six — Missing

Book Seven — Command Performance

Book Eight — The Strange Emergence of Ms. Peel

Book Nine — Five Comedians Walk into a Bar

Book Ten — The Big Shoe, Parts One & Two



CHAPTER ONE

THE WATCHER IN THE STATIC

You never know when life's gonna hit you with the punchline. Sometimes it sets the joke up years in advance — decades, even — and lets it sit there, marinating, waiting for the exact wrong moment to pay off. That's not cruelty. That's craftsmanship. And somebody, somewhere, has been taking notes the whole time. OH. OH. OHHHHHH.

The room had no windows, no clock, and no particular allegiance to any decade. Vintage computer equipment crowded every surface — reel-to-reel drives, banks of toggle switches, cables braided like the root system of some electronic tree — and all of it hummed with the patient confidence of machinery that had outlived its warranty by half a century and intended to keep going out of spite.

The only light worth mentioning came from an old IBM monitor, casting its blue glow across a desk and across a pair of gloved hands that moved over the keyboard with the unhurried precision of long practice.

The screen displayed:

```
TEMPORAL      OBSERVATION      SYSTEM      VI.992
INITIALIZING... ACCESS GRANTED ENTER PARAMETERS:
DATE: \_
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The hands typed: *04-11-1992*

LOCATION: _

They entered: *KINISON HOMESTEAD*

CALIBRATING TEMPORAL LENS... ESTABLISHING
OBSERVATION POINT...

The screen flickered, static building like a held breath. A joystick on the desk moved slightly — adjusting the viewing angle, the way a person leans to see around a doorframe. The monitor's display began to ripple, colors swirling, until an image started to form.

Here is a thing worth knowing about watching the past: the past does not know it is being watched. It goes about its business — its breakfasts, its arguments, its small ordinary heartbreaks — with the unselfconscious ease of people who believe the moment belongs only to them. The observer at the keyboard understood this better than anyone alive, if indeed the observer qualified as either.

The static cleared.

A backyard. Spring light. A boy and a dog.



Young Derek Kinison was out back of the house playing fetch with the family dog, engaged in the great and ancient negotiation between a boy who wants the stick thrown forever and a dog who has personally never once returned a stick to the correct location. His mother came to the back door and called for him to come inside. Derek threw the stick one more time — a boy's instinct for a proper goodbye — and ran in.

"You wanted to see me, Ma?" he asked, a little out of breath.

Mrs. Kinison was sitting at the kitchen table, and she appeared very upset, holding a handful of Kleenex the way people do when the box has already been emptied once. "Sit here beside me, darling. I have something I need to talk to you about," she said, pulling a chair up beside her.

Derek sat. Something in the kitchen felt wrong — the light, the quiet, the Kleenex. He was five years old, but five-year-olds are better detectives than anyone gives them credit for, and this had the exact shape of the day last fall when Mrs. Harrowsmith, the neighbor, had passed away.

"Is this going to be another talk like we had when Mrs. Harrowsmith passed away last fall?"

"Yes, I'm afraid so, honey. You see, your uncle Sam was driving to a show in Nevada—"

"No, don't say that." The tears were already streaming. "Uncle Sam said he was coming here in a couple weeks—" and then the words gave out entirely and he launched into a full-on bawl as his mother hugged him.

"I am so sorry, Derek. I know how much you loved your uncle Sam. But rest assured, he is up in Heaven with his brother, making everyone laugh. That sure was Sam's gift, and we are all going to miss him."

Derek pushed away from his mother and ran to the bedroom he shared with his sister June. June was already lying in bed crying when she saw Derek come into the room, also crying. He spotted his sister and crawled into bed, where the two of them hugged each other and continued to cry — two small people holding on through the first storm either of them had ever been given no umbrella for.

There is no good way to explain death to a five-year-old, and the universe knows it, which is why it usually delegates the job to mothers with Kleenex. What Derek understood, in the wordless way children understand things, was that the loudest, funniest, most alive person he had ever known had been subtracted from the world, and that the world had somehow been allowed to keep spinning anyway. It seemed like an administrative error. He kept waiting for someone to fix it.

Someone, as it happens, was working on it. But that part of the story was still thirty-three years away.



In the windowless room, the screen flickered with static before displaying:

TEMPORAL ANALYSIS COMPLETE SUBJECT: DEREK KINISON AGE: 5 YEARS, 5 MONTHS QUANTUM CONSCIOUSNESS READING: 17% ABOVE BASELINE NOTE: First recorded manifestation of empathic resonance with subject SAM KINISON ANOMALY DETECTED: Residual energy signature matches RAVENCREST PARAMETERS RECOMMENDATION: Further temporal observation required

The gloved hands pulled back from the keyboard and reached for an old leather journal, opening it to reveal pages filled with complex equations and diagrams — diagrams that matched, line for line, the patterns worked into the architecture of a certain mansion on a certain cliff. A note was made in careful script: *Subject shows early quantum resonance — genetic component confirmed.*

The hands moved to enter new coordinates, hesitating briefly over the keyboard, the way one hesitates before turning a page in someone else's diary. A second monitor sprang to life, displaying complex waveform patterns labeled CONSCIOUSNESS HARMONICS.

The gloved hands returned to the keyboard:

TEMPORAL SHIFT REQUESTED DATE: 2007 LOCATION: BAYLOR UNIVERSITY — DEREK KINISON DORMITORY

The screen rippled again, reality bending politely out of the way.



Baylor University, 2007. Fifteen years had done what fifteen years does: the boy who had cried in his sister's arms was now a young man with his uncle's grin and none of the grief showing, at least not where anyone could bill him for it. His dorm room existed in the state of catastrophic archaeology that only a college student can achieve in under an hour, and standing at the center of the excavation site: Derek Kinison, twenty years old, getting ready to go out and losing the battle.

"Stan, I have to find my wallet... can you go look in the common room for me while I tear my room apart?"

"What's the big deal? It will show itself eventually," Stan said, with the serenity of a man whose own wallet was exactly where it should be. "If you need a couple bucks, I think I have seventy-five dollars on me."

"Nancy arrives at the bus station in thirty minutes, and I need my license. I can't be late again, or she will kill me." Derek continued to dig through his dresser drawers, throwing clothes on the floor in an escalating snowfall of laundry.

"Did you check the car?"

"No, why?"

"Don't you recall you took it out when we stopped at the liquor store earlier, and then threw it in the glove box when we got back in with the booze?"

Derek stopped. He went into a bit of a trance — the specific thousand-yard stare of a man watching his own memory rewind. Then suddenly he looked at Stan. "You may be one ugly bastard, but you got one hell of a brain, Stanley. Can you do me a solid and run down and grab it for me? I have to clean this room up and finish getting ready... I will owe you bigtime!"

"Why is it that you Kinisons think you can insult people and then have them jump to attention when you want something?"

"Because I can still drop my uncle's name and get us into the hottest parties, my follically challenged friend. Not to mention, you still owe me for that Queen album you borrowed and never gave back."



The observer leaned forward, adjusting a dial that increased image clarity. A gloved hand reached toward the second monitor, where a complex diagram now showed two interweaving lines, labeled KINISON and BLACKWOOD. As the observer watched, a third line — labeled HAMMOND — began to intersect with them, threading itself into the weave like it had always been meant to be there.



Thirty minutes later — twenty-nine of which had been spent on the room and one on the drive, in flagrant violation of physics and campus speed limits — Derek ran up to the front doors of the Waco bus station just as his gal Nancy Hammond was exiting them.

"Hey babe, sorry I am a little late, but I could not—"

"Yes, I have heard this before, Mr. Never On Time," Nancy said, handing him her suitcase in the same motion, a maneuver executed with the smoothness of long-established protocol.

Derek grabbed the bag, leaned in, and gave her a kiss on the cheek. "God, what did you bring? You're here for, like, two nights."

Nancy opened the door for Derek — the suitcase-holder, after all, needs assistance — and the two exited the final set of doors. "Well, for one, you never did tell me what we were going to do while I was here. And second, I have a paper due on Monday and

need to spend a couple hours finishing it, and you're carrying three huge textbooks I need to reference."

"Well, Stan is staying at Larry's for the weekend, so I thought we could go and see *Transformers*."

"I came all this way to watch a stupid sci-fi movie?"

"First, it's not stupid. Second, it gets me extra hot after watching it. Third, I get to look at the second greatest ass of all time, then after the movie, I get to play with the greatest ass of all time." He watched Nancy's face for the reaction, the way a man watches a fuse he has just lit.

"So who has the second best ass?"

Derek made a show of not knowing, an act that would not have fooled a jury of kindergartners. "I think her name is Megan something... Might be Megan Fox."

"Well, Mr. Sci-fi Lover, she better have one hot ass, or there is no way you get to touch this one tonight," Nancy said, giving her behind a sensual little rub, with an added smile that suggested the verdict was probably going to come out in Derek's favor regardless.

They had been doing this dance since high school — the mock outrage, the escalating bids, the smile at the end that settled all accounts. A long-distance relationship runs on exactly two fuels, letters and momentum, and Derek and Nancy had somehow kept both tanks full across state lines, semesters, and one memorably terrible Greyhound schedule. Anyone watching them cross that parking lot, her hand finding his arm out of pure habit, could have told you how this was going to end. Anyone, that is, except the two of them, who still thought they were just dating.



Data scrolled across the screen:

TEMPORAL ANALYSIS UPDATE SUBJECT: DEREK KINISON — AGE: 20 YEARS, 8 MONTHS QUANTUM CONSCIOUSNESS READING: 42% ABOVE BASELINE NOTE: First joint observation of subjects KINISON and HAMMOND ANOMALY DETECTED: Dual consciousness resonance pattern WARNING: Timeline convergence probability increasing RECOMMENDATION: Monitor HAMMOND subject for corresponding quantum signatures

The gloved figure leaned closer to the screen, making a note in the ancient leather-bound journal, whose pages seemed to glow faintly in the dark — as if the paper itself found all of this terribly interesting.

One final command was entered:

TEMPORAL SHIFT REQUESTED DATE: 2016 LOCATION: SAN FRANCISCO — 1879 PACIFIC HEIGHTS DRIVE

The monitor hummed, the image distorting before resolving into daylight.

□ □ □

San Francisco, 2016. Nine more years, another city, two careers ascending in parallel like well-behaved stock charts. Derek and Nancy stood in the driveway of a townhouse they had decided to put an offer in on — a decision reached, as all their major decisions were, by Nancy deciding and Derek being informed at a strategically chosen moment.

"When the agent gets here, I will do all the talking. OK?"

"Why do you get all the fun?"

"Do I need to remind you what happened at the last house we thought would be great?"

"Sure, one time I get excited about a property, and you go and throw it in my face!"

"It was a pool. A bloody pool. You didn't have to jump in just when the agent arrived and then proceed to tell me what a perfect house it was for us. Or have you forgotten how the price suddenly jumped fifty thousand dollars?"

"You have to admit it was a great pool and a great house," Derek said, deploying his cute 'I am so adorable' smile, a weapon whose success rate Nancy had never once publicly acknowledged.

A car arrived and pulled into the driveway. An older Asian woman got out, along with a young man.

"Hello, you must be the Kinisons," the agent said, walking over to greet them.

"Actually, the name is Hammond," Nancy said, extending her hand.

"I am Lora Kim, and this young man is my assistant Trevor. We have the house for thirty minutes, so let's do a walk-through."

Derek, Nancy, and Trevor all walked to the front door, where Ms. Kim opened the real estate lockbox and proceeded to open the door.

"So, what line of work are you two in?" Ms. Kim asked.

"Well, I work for an art gallery, and Derek is in between jobs."

"Oh. Well, hopefully, Mr. Hammond, you will find something soon."

"Well, if not, I can always clean the floors at the art gallery," Derek said, playing along with Nancy's strategy of not tipping the agent off that they were, in fact, quite well off — a strategy he privately rated as her second-best negotiating tactic, right after marrying him.

"So, Lora," Nancy said, "I have taken a thorough look at the listing and even checked out the current status of the property at city hall. Seems they have an outstanding work order regarding the rear fence?"

"Yes, a little dispute with the neighbor at the back of the property. I am sure it can easily be dealt with."

"Well, I think we are prepared to put in an offer for the place, subject to a few items I have taken the liberty to write out on this piece of paper." She handed it to Trevor, who received it with the expression of a man being handed live ordnance.

"Do you think they would allow a pool in the backyard, Ms. Kim?" Derek asked, giving Nancy a pat on her butt when no one was watching.

"Perhaps Trevor can show Mr. Hammond the garage and backyard," Nancy said sweetly, "while I go through the house with Ms. Kim" — and gave Derek a pat on *his* butt when no one was watching, because in this marriage, all accounts were settled promptly.



The screen flickered one final time, displaying:

TEMPORAL OBSERVATION COMPLETE DATE OF
SESSION: APRIL 10, 2025 TIME: 03:17:33 PATTERNS
IDENTIFIED SUBJECT: DEREK KINISON NOTE: QUANTUM
CONSCIOUSNESS INDICATORS PRESENT PROCEEDING
WITH PHASE 2...

The observer sat back. In the blue light, the leather journal lay open to its newest page, where three timelines — a grieving boy, a young man in love, a couple buying their first real home — had been reduced to data points and pinned like butterflies. Thirty-three years of a life, reviewed in a single sitting, the way you might skim

the first act of a play you already knew the ending to.

The observer's gloved hand trembled slightly as they made another note: *Patterns repeating — real estate agents triggering temporal nexus points.*

On a secondary screen, for just a moment, a file was visible. The photograph clipped to it showed a woman with normally perfect hair. The name read LINDA RHODES. Across the top, in red ink, someone had written a single word, followed by a question mark:

BLOODLINE?

A gloved hand reached forward and switched off the monitor, plunging everything into darkness — the kind of darkness that isn't empty so much as *waiting*.



CHAPTER TWO

EIGHT HOURS TO SUNSET

Morning at Ravencrest Mansion arrived the way everything arrived at Ravencrest: with production values.

The mansion had spent the night doing whatever mansions of its temperament do in the dark — settling, creaking, rehearsing — and it greeted the new day looking exactly as it had the day before, which is to say, like a building that had read too much Gothic literature and taken it personally. Its two sets of overnight guests-to-be had returned for their instructions, and the house observed them through its tall windows with the appraising patience of a booking agent watching auditions.

Thunder rumbled outside as Linda Rhodes stood before both couples in the grand foyer, her normally perfect hair showing signs of disarray — which, for Linda, was roughly equivalent to another person showing up on fire. Through the windows, storm clouds gathered ominously over the Pacific, stacking themselves with the enthusiasm of a crew that had been told the budget was unlimited.

Linda consulted her watch. "The challenge begins at sunset. You have until then to... prepare."

"Perfect!" Chad said. "Our crew's already on their way."

Derek leaned toward Nancy, quietly. "We should get supplies."

"Supplies?" Marina said, examining her manicure while eavesdropping — a skill she had honed across a decade of industry parties. "Like, ghost hunting equipment?"

"Like sleeping bags," Nancy said. "Unless you plan to sleep on hundred-year-old mattresses."

Thunder crashed. The chandelier swayed slightly, crystal pieces tinkling like polite applause.

And underneath it, barely audible, like wind through cracks in old plaster, a voice:

"Smart girl..."

Outside, a black van pulled up, PARANORMAL PRODUCTIONS emblazoned on its side in Gothic lettering that had clearly been chosen from a font menu under the search term "spooky." Two young crew members emerged: Joey, twenty-five, hipster-casual, and Kevin, twenty-three, so tech-obsessed he appeared to be wearing at least three devices that monitored the other devices. They unloaded gear with the cheerful efficiency of young men who had filmed a dozen "haunted" locations and had yet to meet one that was.

The mansion, it should be noted, had met a great many young men like Joey and Kevin over the years. It was very much looking forward to the evening.

Linda checked her watch again, nervous now. "You have eight hours. Be back before sunset or..." She hesitated, meaningfully. "...forfeit."

The word hung in the foyer a beat longer than physics required. Nobody asked what, exactly, would be forfeited. It was that kind of word, in that kind of house.



Two vehicles pulled away from the mansion — Derek's Tesla and Chad's Range Rover, followed by the production van, a little convoy of ambition descending the cliff road. Linda watched from the widow's walk, phone pressed to her ear, her figure a dark silhouette against the stormy sky. From below, she might have been part of the architecture. Perhaps, in some sense, she was.

Inside the Tesla, Nancy studied a local map on her phone while Derek navigated the winding coastal road. Rain began to spatter the windshield.

"There's a camping store in town," Nancy said. "Harrison's Outdoor Supply."

"Harrison... like Dr. 'Harrison' Blackwood from the portrait?"

"Probably just a coincidence."

In the rearview mirror, Derek's reflection briefly morphed into Sam's face, complete with signature beret — there and gone between one heartbeat and the next. Derek blinked, and it was just Derek again, and the mirror offered no further comment.

Probably just a coincidence, the town seemed to agree, in the way towns do when they are lying.



Main Street was a quaint tourist strip with Gothic undertones, the kind of place where every third building looked like it had a secret and the other two were keeping it. It was the sort of town that appears on postcards captioned "charming" and in local legends captioned considerably otherwise — a town that had long ago worked out its arrangement with the mansion on the cliff and did not discuss the terms with outsiders. Storm clouds loomed overhead, casting everything in premature twilight. Shop signs creaked in the wind: MADAME RAVEN'S CURIOSITIES. THE LAST LAUGH DINER.

If you were paying attention — and Derek, lately, could not seem to stop paying attention — you might notice that an unusual number of the town's establishments were named for laughter, ravens, or last things. Nobody in town seemed to find this remarkable. That, too, was worth noticing.

The Tesla and Range Rover caravan found parking. Marina immediately began filming with her phone, striking poses against the gloomy backdrop with the mechanical grace of an athlete warming up.

"Day one of our haunted mansion adventure!" she told the camera, influencer-perfect. "Don't forget to like and subscribe!"

The town, which had been gloomy for a hundred years without once asking anyone to subscribe, declined to comment.

□ □ □

CHAPTER THREE

EVERYBODY PLAYED HERE

Derek and Nancy entered Harrison's Outdoor Supply, the bell above the door chiming softly. The cluttered store was packed with camping gear and local history in roughly equal measure — tents shelved beside framed photographs, lantern fuel beside newspaper clippings gone the color of weak tea — as if the establishment couldn't quite decide whether it was outfitting expeditions or curating them, much as its proprietor had suggested when they'd met him earlier at the gas station, asking for directions and charging the Tesla. Earl looked up from behind the ancient counter with that same knowing expression on his weathered face, the expression of a man who had been expecting you specifically since roughly the Carter administration.

"Thought you folks might find your way here," he said, setting aside the book he'd been reading — *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*, the current number one bestseller on the New York Times list. "Figured you'd need proper supplies after seeing the mansion."

"You didn't mention you owned the supply store too," Nancy observed, examining a shelf of lanterns.

Earl's eyes crinkled with amusement. "Didn't mention a lot of things at the station. Some stories need the right setting." He gestured to a sepia photograph on the wall that had caught Derek's attention — the mansion in the 1950s, with Dr. Blackwood standing proudly on the front steps, looking like a man who believed history would remember him fondly and had made certain arrangements to ensure it. "Like how my grandfather used to work maintenance at the old asylum. Or how Doc Blackwood's 'treatment through laughter' program changed everything for this town."

He leaned on the counter. "I gather you folks made it up to Ravenscrest already."

"We did," Derek said. "Met with the real estate agent, Linda Rhodes. Looks like we are going to be staying the night at the old place."

Earl interrupted with a knowing smile. "Nobody buys sleeping bags around here unless they're staying up there, so let me suggest the bags over there." He pointed to an upper shelf. "Mostly YouTuber types."

"We already met a couple like that!"

"Doc Blackwood had big plans for that place," Earl said, noticing Derek's interest. "Treatment through laughter, he called it. Brought in comedians to perform for the patients. Patch Adams before Patch Adams." A brief, knowing chuckle.

Nancy moved closer to the counter and began inspecting various headlamp-style flashlights, in the manner of a woman who intended to be the only person in her party capable of seeing.

Earl moved to straighten some items on the counter, his voice dropping into the register people reserve for stories they've been keeping warm for years. "Most folks don't know this, but when Doc Blackwood passed, there was quite the stir. Found him in the study — I think it was his granddaughter, actually, they say — face frozen in this terrible expression, like he'd seen... well, something that shouldn't be seen."

"What happened to him?" Nancy asked, intrigued despite herself.

"That's the thing. When they went to do the burial..." He glanced around conspiratorially, though the store was empty save for a stuffed owl that had heard the story before. "Empty coffin. Just vanished. Like the man had never been there at all. Same thing

happened with a few others over the years. Strange pattern in this town — people connected to that mansion having... unusual endings."

"Others?" Derek said.

"Your cousin wasn't the first performer to have an... accident after playing the mansion. Though he was certainly the most famous." A beat. "You know, they never did find all of Sam's personal effects after his crash. Just his beret, sitting perfect as you please on the passenger seat."

Nancy turned from the lanterns. "Wait... it was a comedy venue even back then?"

Thunder rumbled outside. The store's fluorescent lights flickered ominously, as if the building itself were clearing its throat.

Through the rain-streaked window, they watched Chad and Marina enter The Last Laugh Diner across the street.



The Last Laugh Diner was a classic American diner with a decidedly comedic twist. Headshots and publicity photos of famous comedians covered every available inch of wall space — a congregation of grins watching over the booths like patron saints of the two-drink minimum. Some of the photos were signed. Some were signed to people whose names had been carefully scratched out. One or two, if you looked closely, appeared to have been signed *recently*, in ink that hadn't fully dried on paper that had yellowed forty years ago. Nobody ever looked closely.

Joey and Kevin set up cameras while Chad and Marina settled into a red vinyl booth.

Betty — sixties, a waitress with the seen-it-all bearing of a woman who had, in fact, seen it all, twice, and been under-tipped both times — approached their table, coffee pot in hand.

"You must be the LA folks Linda mentioned."

"Look, Chad darling, we're already famous," Marina said. "We're going to make that mansion famous! Any chance I could get a cappuccino with non-fat foam?"

Betty's expression went deadly serious. "It's already famous, honey. Ask anyone about the night Sam Kinison played there. For that matter, you name any comedian, and I'll bet you breakfast they played there. As far as a cappuccino with non-fat foam — I can maybe dump some old coffee grinds in to make it stronger and hit it with some whipped cream in a can we use for the hot chocolate."

"The coffee will be fine, thank you," Marina said, shooting Chad the 'what a hick' look she did so well — a look Betty catalogued, filed, and would be repaying with interest via refill latency for the remainder of their visit.

"April 9th, 1992," Betty said. "Last show before..." She made a crossing gesture. "They say his spirit never left. Some even say his car accident was not an accident, but—"

A big thunder crash. The lights flickered — and an ominous sound rippled around the room, like every picture on the wall had let out a gasp.



Across the street, Earl was still going.

"Your cousin was something else. Changed comedy forever."

Derek startled. "How do you know I'm related?"

Earl grinned, cryptic. "News travels fast around this town, Junior. May also have something to do with your credit card receipt."

Derek laughed despite himself. "You saw him perform?"

"Once. Right here in town, at the old Buster Keaton Pub. He had this way of... screaming the truth. Made you laugh and think at the same time." Earl studied Derek intently. "You got his eyes, you know. That same look, like you're seeing something the rest of us can't."

"He's been doing that more lately," Nancy said, watching Derek carefully. "Seeing things."

Earl disappeared into the back room. He returned with a weathered paper bag, presenting it with the ceremony of a man handing over something that had been waiting a long time to be handed over.

"Found this in the basement last time I was up there helping Larry do some repairs."

Derek opened the bag, peered in — and let out a genuine laugh, the first real one anyone had heard from him in this town. "It would appear Larry is still working there."

"Might look good on you," Earl said. "Just collecting dust here."

Nancy tried to peek in the bag, but Derek closed it quickly, still grinning, holding it out of reach with the practiced defense of a younger brother who had spent his childhood protecting Halloween candy from June.

Earl handed Derek a yellowed flyer. "Found this too. Same night."

The flyer read: THE LAUGH ASYLUM presents SAM KINISON. The date was smudged but visible: April 9th, 1992.

"Look at the date," Nancy said.

"That's impossible," Derek said. "I'm sure Sam was in Los Angeles, driving to Nevada to a show, the night he died. Why would he do a show here, then drive to LA right after, to then turn around and head to Nevada?"

Earl glanced at the gathering storm clouds through the window. "History has a way of getting blurry up at Ravenscrest. Especially on nights like this. Besides — he performed on the 9th and passed on the 10th. So it is possible both things are true."

It was the kind of statement that should have invited follow-up questions, and Earl delivered it with the placid finality of a man who had learned exactly where to stop a story so that it kept working on you after you left. Derek looked at the flyer again. The smudged date looked back. Somewhere between Los Angeles and a coastal town nobody had mentioned in any biography, thirty-three years of official record had quietly developed a gap the size of one night.



Outside, Nancy loaded supplies into the Tesla while Derek sat in the driver's seat, staring at the paper bag in his lap the way a man stares at a letter he hasn't decided whether to open.

Nancy got in the car. "Remember our first apartment? That mattress on the floor, no furniture..."

"Eating takeout because we couldn't afford a kitchen table."

"We were happy," she said, looking at him longingly.

Derek took her hand. "We still are. This place... it's not just about Sam. It's about us having something that's ours. No more corporate meetings, no more gallery politics..."

"Just ghosts, weird comedy routines, and hopefully an unlimited supply of fresh milk showing up in the fridge?" Nancy said, with a cute smile.

Derek smiled back. "And us. Together."

"If you use the 'You Complete Me' line again, then this adventure is over, and we will be heading home and getting you

needed therapy sessions." She gave him her stern-but-cute look, patent pending.

Thunder crashed. Through the store window, they could see Betty in the diner making the crossing gesture again as Chad and Marina's crew packed up.



As both parties finished loading their vehicles, the town seemed to darken under the growing storm. Store signs creaked ominously in the rising wind, an entire street clearing its throat for the second act.

Derek carefully placed the paper bag in the trunk, under the sleeping bags. For a moment, before the bag settled, there was a glimpse of black fabric and the unmistakable curve of a beret.

"Booze, babe," Derek said.

"Smartest thing you have said today. I hope they're open this early."

They drove slowly east on Main Street, hunting for the Only Good Liquor store Earl had mentioned during their chat at Harrison's — a name that raised certain philosophical questions about all the other liquor in town. As the Tesla rolled along, Derek and Nancy looked right at an old, Gothic-style church with a sign reading E.A. POE EPISCOPALIAN CHURCH, which was either the most on-brand church name in America or a warning label.

As they passed, Nancy saw a young woman in a dark hoodie carrying what looked like a glowing blue cube-like device, slipping in through the back door of the building — while at the same moment, Linda Rhodes was entering through the front.

"Look, Derek — isn't that the agent, Rhodes, entering the church?"

"Maybe she needs to pray on who should win the contest."

"This place is right out of some Stephen King novel."

"There's the booze shop. Want me to grab beer or wine?"

"What we don't drink we can always take home, so grab a couple bottles of wine, a six-pack of beer, and if you have to, buy a bottle of your favourite Port."

"Now, Miss Nancy. Would you be thinking you're going to try to get me liquored up and take advantage of me?"

Nancy got into the spirit of the moment. "Well, Master Kinison, would you be opposed to being taken advantage of by a cute, smart, sexually desirable young woman with a..." — and here she attempted, with more enthusiasm than accuracy, an Al Pacino growl — "...great... assssss..."

Somewhere overhead, thunder rolled its eyes.

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CHAPTER FOUR

HOUSE RULES

Sunset at Ravencrest arrived early, because the storm insisted.

The two vehicles had made it back up the cliff road with minutes to spare — Derek and Nancy with sleeping bags, wine, and one paper bag riding in the trunk like contraband; Chad and Marina with a van full of equipment and a crew of two who had already begun narrating everything in trailer voice. The mansion's front doors stood open for them, which nobody remembered arranging.

Linda stood before both couples and the camera crew in the mansion foyer, the ancient ledger lying open in her hands like a hymnal for a very unusual congregation. Whatever errand had taken her to the E.A. Poe Episcopal Church that afternoon, it had returned her composed, punctual, and holding a book that looked old enough to have opinions. Thunder boomed outside.

"Now..." she said. "Shall we discuss the rules?"

Lightning flashed against every window, and the chandelier trembled, and somewhere deep in the mansion something settled into place with the satisfaction of a theater manager watching the house fill up.

The evening had begun.



Night. The West Wing.

The rules had been read, the wings assigned, the coin tossed and lost — or possibly, depending on whose account you believed, strategically surrendered. The two couples had parted at the grand

staircase like duelists pacing off, Chad already narrating into a camera, Marina already checking her light. The mansion had watched them go their separate ways with what could only be described as anticipation.

Moonlight filtered through rain-streaked windows as Derek and Nancy explored their assigned territory. Their headlamp beams cut through darkness, creating dancing shadows among the sheet-draped Victorian furniture — a room full of pale, patient shapes, like ghosts who had unionized and were waiting for their shift to start. Every floorboard announced them three rooms in advance. The house did not believe in surprises it hadn't personally arranged.

"A simple coin toss, and you lose a fifty-fifty chance. Not a good sign, babe." Nancy poked Derek in the side with her finger.

"How would you know that I didn't actually throw the toss because I thought they would choose the wrong wing?"

Nancy gave Derek the old *don't try that logic crap on me, Mister* look, an expression that had been peer-reviewed over ten years of marriage.

"Basic utilities, she said. Why do I feel like we're in *The Shining*?"

"It's the West Wing... How can it not be the best? Who knows, we may even run into old President Jed Bartlet."

Thunder crashed. A white sheet suddenly billowed upward — untouched, unbothered by anything so mundane as airflow — revealing an ornate mirror. In its reflection, Derek wore Sam's beret.

His actual head remained bare.

"Sam wore that beret the last time he was alive," Derek said thoughtfully, gazing at the reflection that had decided to accessorize him. "On that fateful night of April 10th, 1992. Did you

know he had just remarried a week before, to some twenty-year-old girl he met at his show?"

"Glad you didn't get those genes," Nancy said with a playful grin. Then, after a beat: "Isn't it weird, though? The day he died... is the same day the previous owner died. I think I read somewhere that the owner died shortly before Sam's fateful car crash. I can't recall where I read that."

They passed a wall of framed comedy club posters — decades of one-night-onlys, a paper museum of punchlines. One caught Derek's eye: THE LAUGH ASYLUM presents SAM KINISON — ONE NIGHT ONLY — April 9th, 1992.

"That's impossible," Derek said, puzzled. "Sam never played here."

"That's not what Earl claimed."

The poster rippled like water. Its image shifted before their eyes — morphing to *Young Frankenstein*, then to *Back to School* — before returning to Sam's image, as if the wall were shuffling through its memories and had briefly lost its place.

Nancy touched the wall, sensing something under her fingertips that wasn't quite vibration and wasn't quite warmth. "So you get the feeling the house... it's like it's trying to tell us something."

From somewhere below came the distinct sound of a microphone being tapped.

Then: muffled laughter.



In the East Wing, at the same time, Chad and Marina were directing their crew in the deployment of enough high-tech ghost hunting equipment to invade a small haunted country. Marina checked her makeup in an antique mirror, adjusting her hair with

the focus of a surgeon.

"Think bigger, babe," Chad was saying. "We flip this place into 'The Comedy Spirit Club' — exclusive memberships, celebrity séances..."

"Ooh!" Marina said, excited. "Ghost hunting reality show tie-in!"

Thunder crashed. Every piece of electronic equipment simultaneously went dark — cameras, monitors, meters, all of it, a synchronized blackout executed with suspiciously good comic timing.

"Hey! Those are brand new—"

A voice echoed from everywhere and nowhere: "OH... OHHHHHHH! *Looking for content, kids?*"

In the antique mirror, Marina's reflection transformed into Sam's grinning face.

She screamed. The mansion, one suspects, considered it a standing ovation.



In the mansion library, Linda sat alone in a leather chair, phone pressed to her ear. Lightning flashed through the tall windows, strobing the room in black and silver.

"I am about to leave," she said, hushed. "I will meet you back at the church in fifteen minutes. They're all in position..." She listened. "Yes, I know about the deadline..." A pause. "The comedy club is still sealed..." Her composure slipped one degree further. "What do you mean, 'he's already here'?"

Thunder crashed — and the mansion plunged into total darkness.



In the West Wing hallway, moving by headlamp through the blackout, Nancy's beam found a door marked ARCHIVES. Inside: towering stacks of VHS tapes, film reels, and a wall of yellowing photographs — the mansion's memory, filed but not forgotten. The air in the room had the hush of a library and the charge of a green room five minutes before showtime.

"Derek..."

A black-and-white photo showed Sam on stage at The Laugh Asylum, a strange, almost glowing microphone in hand. The date stamp read: April 9th, 1992. Next to it hung a death certificate for the previous owner, cause of death listed as *circumstances unknown* — bureaucracy's way of shrugging.

"He was here," Derek said, realization dawning. "The night before he died, Sam was—"

A VHS tape fell from a shelf and landed at their feet, in the precise manner of an object that had jumped. The label read: SAM'S LAST SHOW.

From somewhere below, Sam's legendary scream echoed up through the floorboards, followed by ghostly audience laughter — a full house, decades past its curfew.

Nancy grabbed Derek's arm. "Please tell me you heard that."

"Oh, I heard it alright," Derek said — and the voice that came out of him wasn't entirely his own. It was Sam's. "And the show's just getting started..."

He felt it before he could name it, the same slippage he'd felt in the boardroom the day everything changed: a sensation like leaning back in a chair and having someone else catch you. It should have frightened him. That was the strange part — the part he hadn't told Nancy yet, and suspected she already knew. It felt less like being taken over and more like being *handed something*. A microphone,

maybe.

Thunder crashed. Down the hallway, a door marked BASEMENT ACCESS slowly creaked open, revealing absolute darkness beyond — the kind of darkness that comes with a two-drink minimum.

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CHAPTER FIVE

THE MIRROR HAS OPINIONS

The East Wing bathroom was a shrine to Victorian plumbing, all ornate fixtures gleaming in moonlight. Marina touched up her makeup in the antique mirror, her movements precise and practiced — a ritual performed nightly for twenty years, give or take the years her publicist had amortized away. It was, in truth, the only moment of her day that belonged entirely to her: no camera, no Chad, no audience except the one in the glass, who could always be counted on to agree with her.

Tonight, the audience had other plans.

Thunder crashed outside, and the bedroom door slammed shut behind her.

"Still got it, honey," she told her reflection. "Still—"

Her reflection aged twenty years before her eyes.

Then forty.

Her perfect skin wrinkled, her hair greyed, youth melting away like ice in summer.

"What the... No... no no NO!"

She splashed water on her face. Looked up. Young again. Relief flooded her features — and then, immediately, she aged again. Back and forth with each blink, the mirror flipping through the pages of her like a casting director in a hurry.

A new face appeared in the glass, adjusting his tie. Rodney Dangerfield.

"I tell ya, you're aging so fast, you got crow's feet on your crow's feet!" He tugged his collar. "Your wrinkles are getting so deep, spelunkers are asking for permits! Your plastic surgeon doesn't need a medical license anymore — he needs a contractor's permit!"

Marina gasped. The reflection shifted, rippling like disturbed water, and resolved into Joan Rivers.

"Oh, grow up, honey. You're sagging so much, your plastic surgeon needs a contractor's license!"

Rodney's reflection shoved back in, indignant. "Hey, Joan, that was my joke... I get no respect, even in this two-bit rehashed storyline." He turned to Marina. "Hey kid, why not try to be original — like Joan..."

"Rodney... BITE ME!" Joan snapped, then returned to her audience of one. "Where was I? Oh yeah... Your face has had more work done than the 405 freeway, and honey, the traffic's just as bad!"

Marina scrambled for the door. The handle wouldn't budge. And through the wood, she heard Chad's voice:

"Yeah, she's totally losing it... No, like, literally aging before my eyes..."

Marina pressed her ear to the door, mascara running.

A sultry female voice answered him, silk over static. "Poor thing. Well, about that haunted hospital show... We need someone fresh. Young. Like me."

"Marina was young once too," Chad's voice said. "But now..."

"Chad?" Marina pounded on the door. "CHAD!"

The mirror rippled again. Don Rickles leaned out of it like a man leaning over a fence to watch a neighbor's house burn down.

"Honey, you're so desperate, you're eavesdropping on hallucinations!" Rapid-fire now: "You're so pathetic, even imaginary voices are hanging up on you!" He leaned in. "Look at you, taking relationship advice from a mirror. What's next, dating your reflection?" And the finishing blow: "Hey, at least the voices in your head are getting better ratings than your show!"

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In the East Wing bedroom — reveal: Chad stood alone, fiddling with dead camera equipment, having said none of it.

Through the bathroom door, he heard moans.

"OH OH OHHHH! MARINA! That's it, baby!" Sam's voice.

Then Marina's voice, breathless: *"Oh Sam! You're amazing! So much more of a man than Chad!"*

Chad froze, then pressed his ear against the door.

"What do you expect from a Ken doll? OH OH OHHHH! At least Ken had an excuse for having no package! Your boy's just naturally cursed — or should I say Hungless!"

On either side of one locked door, two people listened to betrayals that weren't happening, each broadcast produced, directed, and mixed live by the house — which had apparently decided that what this couple needed was not counseling but *programming*.

And here is the uncomfortable truth about the mansion's methods, the one the mansion itself would never apologize for: it wasn't inventing anything. Every word of it — Chad's roving eye, Marina's terror of the calendar, the mutual contempt dressed up in couple's merchandise — was already there, in inventory, waiting. The house merely gave it a time slot. A lie built out of truths is still a lie, but it books much better ratings.



CHAPTER SIX

TWO OUT OF THREE AIN'T BAD

The West Wing study, meanwhile, was running an entirely different format.

Derek and Nancy sat on their sleeping bags, sharing memories and a bottle of wine. Moonlight streamed through rain-streaked windows, creating shifting patterns on the hardwood floor, and for once the thunder kept a respectful distance, like a waiter who knows when not to approach the table.

"Remember the owl at the Hermitage?" Nancy asked.

"Was that the same time you stripped down to your birthday suit trying to lure me off the Hermitage wall?"

"NO, smarty pants, the owl time, and you know exactly what I mean..."

"You mean the one that almost made me soil myself when it swooped down from the tree."

"Yes, that one. You know why it was a big deal to me?"

"No, I don't have a clue. It was just an owl."

"Because it showed me you could be scared. You always tried to hold yourself out like you were Mr. Invincible. The owl made you look like the person I was looking for."

"If I knew you were into guys soiling themselves, I would have crapped my drawers way sooner," Derek said, attempting a cute face over the rim of his wine.

Nancy gave him a slap on the arm. "That owl at the Hermitage really did us a favor."

This was the thing about ten years of marriage that nobody put in the brochures: the stories got better with repetition, not worse. The owl had been retold a hundred times, and every telling sanded it a little smoother and a little funnier, until it wasn't really a story about an owl at all. It was a story about the exact moment Nancy Hammond decided that the invincible boy was worth keeping — told and retold as a way of deciding it again.

"Best wingman ever." Then Derek spotted the beret, sitting where he'd left it on top of the paper bag. "Speaking of wingmen..."

He put on Sam's beret, tilting it rakishly. The moonlight caught the fabric, making it seem to shimmer — although it is entirely possible the beret was simply pleased.

"OH OH OHHHH!" Derek said, in Sam's voice. "What's a nice girl like you doing in a haunted mansion like this?"

Nancy laughed, playing along, and dropped into a sultry register. "Waiting for a comedian to sweep me off my feet."

A faint snare drum sounded through the room, followed by a cymbal hit. They exchanged surprised looks. Somewhere in this house, apparently, there was a rimshot on retainer.

"Baby, I'll do more than sweep," Derek said, still in Sam's voice. "I'll vacuum, dust, AND do windows! OH OH OHHHH!"

They both dissolved into laughter. Derek pulled her close for a kiss.

"The beret stays on," Nancy said.

"Kinky. Sam would approve."

Thunder crashed — playfully, like mood lighting. And the pipe organ, somewhere below, began to play Rod Stewart's "Tonight's the Night."



Elsewhere, the East Wing bathroom had escalated to a full wall of mirrors, each one hosting a different comedy legend, their faces shifting and changing with each flash of lightning — an open mic where the audience was one terrified influencer and attendance was mandatory.

"Seven words you can't say on television," George Carlin's reflection announced, "and honey, your face is six of 'em!"

"Girl, you ain't aging like fine wine," Richard Pryor's reflection said. "More like milk left out in the sun!"

"Stop it!" Marina's mascara was running in earnest now. "I'm still beautiful!"

Phyllis Diller's reflection cackled. "Sweetie, you're so desperate for attention, you're arguing with dead comedians. Even my plastic surgeon says that's a new low!"

Outside, Chad continued rattling the door, treated to more of Sam and "Marina's" passionate encounter.

"OH OH OHHHH! Now THIS is what I call a comeback!"

"Chad?" Marina pounded frantically. "Let me out! Please!"

The mirrors suddenly showed rapid-fire visions: Marina and Chad twenty years from now — her desperately clinging to fading youth, him with a younger woman wearing a "Ghost Hunters: Next Generation" jacket.

Marina turned from the visions. "No... please... I want to go home!"

"Time for the truth, baby!" Sam's voice, everywhere and nowhere. "And unlike your looks and career, the truth never gets old! OH OH OHHHH!"



Back in the study, Derek and Nancy slow danced as Meat Loaf appeared in the mirror, singing "Two Out of Three Ain't Bad," the pipe organ providing ethereal accompaniment. It was, by any objective measure, an absurd scene — two people swaying in headlamp glow among sheet-draped furniture while a departed rock legend serenaded them from an antique mirror — and neither of them would have traded it for any ballroom on earth. Derek's beret remained rakishly tilted, holding its angle with professional pride.

"You know what I love about you?" Nancy asked.

"My rugged good looks? My charm? My uncle's hat collection?"

"You make me laugh. You always have." A beat. "What made you ask me to dance that first time at the Collins Hotel? Was it my cute dimples?" She forced an exaggerated smile, dimples deployed at maximum wattage.

Derek suddenly channeled Al Pacino from *Heat*: "No, it was... 'cause she has a GREAT ASS!"

Nancy pulled back and stared at him. Their expressions held for exactly as long as either could manage — then slowly cracked into grins, and they kissed, passionately, as Derek moved one hand down to Nancy's butt cheek and gave it a playful squeeze, closing a callback nineteen years in the making.

"I wonder if we should go help them?" Derek said, breaking the kiss.

"In a minute," Nancy said, eyes locked on his. "Sam's not done teaching them about comedy."

"And timing is everything."

Thunder crashed in perfect comedic rhythm — proof, if any were needed, that somebody up in the rafters was running the board.



CHAPTER SEVEN

THE PUNCHLINE

In the East Wing hallway, the show had entered its second hour, and the house — a firm believer in the comedy rule that a callback must always come back bigger — had turned the whole bit up past eleven. Chad had graduated from listening at the bathroom door to banging on it with both fists, while inside, the phantom encounter he could do absolutely nothing about had escalated from suggestive to symphonic.

"OH OH OHHHH! You like that, baby? THIS is how a REAL man handles a woman!"

"Oh Sam! Your package is SO much bigger than Chad's!"

"That's because I'm not anatomically incorrect like your Ken doll Chaddy! OH OH OHHHH!"

Every line landed on Chad like a personalized heckle, which, of course, is exactly what it was.

On the other side of the same door, Marina had stopped hearing any of it. Her broadcast had moved on from the haunted-hospital pitch to pre-production — Chad's voice out in the bedroom, casual as a Tuesday, already dividing up her career like an estate sale.

"Yeah, we'll recast her part. Something fresher. Younger."

"I've got just the girl in mind..." the sultry voice purred.

Marina pounded on the door with the flat of both hands, no longer sure whether she was trying to get out or get *at* him.

Rodney Dangerfield's reflection took the moment for one more set. "I tell ya, getting old is rough. My grandmother started walking five miles a day when she was sixty. She's ninety-seven now, and we

don't know where the hell she is!"

"Shut up, shut up, SHUT UP!"

Suddenly, the door swung open. Chad and Marina tumbled onto the bedroom floor, face to face, each catching the other red-handed at a crime neither had committed. The pipe organ struck up the opening of Foreigner's "Cold as Ice."

"How could you?!" they shouted, simultaneously.

And then the mirrors got involved.

Reflections of musical artists appeared one after another, each delivering the signature line of a breakup anthem as the fight unfolded beneath them — Carly Simon with "You're So Vain," No Doubt with "Don't Speak," Alanis Morissette with "You Oughta Know" — a jukebox of heartbreak curated in real time while Chad and Marina rolled around the floor fighting. Mostly this consisted of Marina trying to slap Chad and Chad blocking her attempts, a bout the ghostly judges were scoring generously for effort.

"You backstabbing son of a bitch!"

"Me? You're the one — I mean, old haggie whore, having ghost sex!"

"At least Sam's more of a man than you'll ever be, you anatomically correct package-less Ken doll!"

"Better than being a has-been who's hit the wall! Face first, by the looks... Face it, Marina — you're DONE!"

"And you're hung like a hamster, you pathetic little man! Just like your loser father!"



In the West Wing study, Derek and Nancy swayed as the pipe organ somehow played contrasting music — romantic for them,

melancholic for the feuding couple — a feat of arrangement no living organist has ever managed. The beret tilted rakishly.

"Sounds like maybe the honeymoon's over," Nancy said.

"Sam always did have perfect timing."

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The argument in the East Wing hallway escalated as the ghostly music continued.

"I made you! You were nothing but a D-list reality show washout!"

"You're a parasite living off my fame, you talentless hack!"

Joey appeared with a camera, somewhat giddy. "Guys? Should I be filming this?"

"Already streaming live, bro," Kevin said. "In fact, for the last fifteen minutes."

Every mirror in the hallway now showed a different late comedian offering commentary, a broadcast booth staffed entirely by the dearly departed.

"You know why they invented filters?" George Carlin's reflection demanded. "Because reality couldn't handle your face! Here's a modern paradox: you're both fake and genuinely horrible! You've got more layers of makeup than the government has lies! What do you want on only sixteen years' notice..."

In another mirror, Johnny Mathis appeared, crooning the opening of "Too Much, Too Little, Too Late."

[AUTHOR INSERT — Mathis lyric line here, per script p.18]

"Man, this some supernatural Jerry Springer shit right here!" Richard Pryor's reflection hollered. "This relationship is burning up faster than my freebasing days! Y'all fighting like two crackheads

over the last rock, except the rock is social media followers! Your love life's more staged than my car accident!"

Deniece Williams shimmered into the glass beside Mathis, lifting the duet's answering line toward its heartbroken finish.

\[AUTHOR INSERT — Williams lyric line here, per script p.18\]

"Oh, grow up!" Joan Rivers' reflection snapped. "You're both so fake, Mattel's suing for copyright infringement!"

The hallway started to spin. Sam's laugh echoed everywhere. The mirrors multiplied, showing Marina aging rapidly; Chad with younger and younger girlfriends; their social media follower counts dropping to zero; their worst career failures on loop — the house running a highlight reel of everything they'd spent their lives outrunning.

"I hate you!" Marina screamed. "I've always hated your stupid content creator dreams!"

"Better than being a plastic surgery nightmare!"

"OH OH OHHHH! Time for the finale!"

The pipe organ blasted a cacophony of lost love and supernatural vengeance — and Ghost Sam appeared in every mirror at once, beret and all, screaming his signature scream, a wall of Sams delivering the closer.

"I want a divorce!"

"You'll have to catch me first, grandma!"

They bolted in opposite directions — then realized, mid-flight, that they had come in the same car. It was the evening's cruelest joke, and the house hadn't even had to write it. Joey and Kevin ran after them, dropping equipment as they went, the sound of very expensive things bouncing down a very old staircase.

And then Taylor Swift appeared in the last mirror by the door, sending them off with "We Are Never Ever Getting Back Together" — the mansion's idea of exit music.



From the West Wing study window, Derek and Nancy watched Chad and Marina's crew throw their gear into the van and flee with Marina, while Chad jumped in the SUV and raced down the drive, two sets of taillights fleeing in formation. It had the choreography of a fire drill and the dignity of one, conducted in a downpour, scored by a pipe organ that had switched — the moment the front doors flew open — to something suspiciously like a recessional.

There are contests that end with a handshake, and contests that end with a judge's ruling, and then there is whatever this had been: a contest that ended with one couple slow dancing in a beret and the other couple discovering, live-streamed, exactly what they were made of.

"Should we tell them those were just special effects?" Derek asked.

"Let them think it's real. Maybe they'll learn something about messing with a Kinison."

"What about the Hammond?"

A smile grew across Nancy's face. She reached over, grabbed the beret off Derek's head, and put it on. "Tonight, I am all Kinison, baby... Oh, Oh, OHHHHHHHHHHH!"

Derek was half laughing and half grinning. "Like, not to mess with a comedy legend?"

"Like, not to mess with *us*."

They kissed. The beret tipped to a perfect angle by itself, because some things a house simply cannot leave to amateurs.

Below them, the taillights dwindled down the cliff road and were swallowed by the storm. The contest, if anyone was still keeping score, had been decided hours ago — probably before either couple had ever set foot in the foyer, possibly before any of them had been born. The mansion did not gloat. The mansion had been picking winners for seventy years, and it considered its record unblemished.



Out on the widow's peak, Linda watched them go, a slight smile playing on her lips — the smile of a woman whose evening had gone precisely to plan, whatever the plan had been. She had spent the night neither in the east wing nor the west, appearing and disappearing through the mansion on her own schedule, keeping appointments she confirmed with no one, and if she had been rooting for either couple, she had kept it as professionally concealed as everything else about her. Somewhere in a windowless room, on a file bearing her photograph, a single red word ended in a question mark. Linda Rhodes had the look of a woman who knew about the file, knew about the question mark, and was in no particular hurry to supply the answer. Behind her, Sam's ghost tipped his beret. In the window glass, Johnny Mathis and Deniece Williams appeared briefly, finishing their duet, holding the last harmony a beat longer than the living ever could.

"OH OH OHHHH! Now THAT'S what I call a punchline!"

Thunder crashed one final time as, in the upstairs bedroom window, Derek and Nancy kissed — while high above them, in the top of the organ loft, the silhouette of Sam appeared, draped over the rail like Riff Raff from *The Rocky Horror Picture Show*, and began to sing "Over at the Frankenstein Place":

[AUTHOR INSERT — Rocky Horror lyric passage here, per script p.19]

— building the final line into his signature scream:

"OH... OH... OH... OHHHHHHHHHHH!"

And the storm, ever the professional, faded to black.

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THE MIRROR GALLERY

In which the management reviews the evening's performance.

The mansion never went straight to sleep after a show. Every venue has its version of this hour — the chairs upturned on tables, the last staff drink, the comics lingering by the bar to relitigate the night's sets — and Ravencrest was no exception, except that its after-hours crowd had all been dead for some time and considered this no obstacle to holding strong opinions. In the long dark hallway, one mirror after another flickered to life, the house's own late-night panel running its post-game commentary to an audience of dust motes and one extremely patient grandfather clock.

Rodney Dangerfield appeared first, adjusting his tie. "I tell ya, these Instagram influencers get no respect! Marina's got so many filters on her face, Google Maps can't find her!"

The mirror rippled to Joan Rivers. "Oh, grow up! Marina's had so much work done, her plastic surgeon gets residuals from the show! And honey, that Chad — he's so shallow, he makes a puddle look like the Pacific Ocean!"

The glass shifted to Sam Kinison himself. "OH OH OHHHH! You see that? Derek and Nancy got the mansion because THEY ACTUALLY LOVE EACH OTHER! Meanwhile, Chad and Marina are so fake, their breakup was sponsored by Joan Rivers' plastic surgeon!"

The mirror transitioned to Don Rickles. "Hey, look who showed up — the department store mannequins trying to be ghost hunters!"

You two couldn't find a spirit in Dean Martin's drink!"

Phyllis Diller cackled into frame. "Honey, I've seen more emotion in Marcel Marceau! Marina's crying was so fake, Halle Berry presented her with an Oscar — her tears were sponsored by Visine!"

The mirror rippled to Robin Williams, speaking rapidly. "Oh man, oh man! Talk about reality TV gone supernatural! These two are so superficial, even their auras have an Instagram filter!"

Andy Kaufman appeared, deadpan. "Their relationship is about as real as my death — but hey, at least I was honest about being dishonest!"

Rodney returned. "I tell ya, this place is tough! The ghosts here are more real than those influencers' follower counts! No respect — I get no respect!"

The mirror shifted to George Carlin, looking irritated, and turning his attention on the show itself. "You ever notice how every scene in this show ends with thunder and lightning? That special effects guy is busier than a dyke in a hardware store! The weather's more dramatic than a soap opera!"

Bob Saget appeared, adjusting his tie. "So many mirror scenes... I hope the writers are sharing their residual cheques with Richard LaGravenese, those larcenous bastards. The writers must've gotten a bulk discount on reflections. And don't get me started on the thunder sound effects — they're using it more than the laugh track on *Full House*!"

The mirror transitioned to Richard Pryor. "Man, they got more fade-to-blacks than a barbershop training video! I don't get the joke about the barbershop. How about, 'more fade-to-blacks than when Michael Jackson got vitiligo.' And every act break's like: 'Thunder CRASHES!' We get it, it's stormy! Damn!"

Bill Hicks leaned into the glass. "You notice how every dramatic revelation happens in front of a mirror? These two spend more time looking at their reflections — it's like two narcissists in a hall of mirrors!"

Andy Kaufman returned. "The stage directions are longer than my wrestling career. THUNDER CRASHES! LIGHTNING FLASHES! PIPE ORGAN PLAYS! It's like the writer gets paid by the capital letter!"

Rodney, one more time. "This script's got more callbacks than my high school girlfriend! Every scene ends with thunder — I haven't heard this much noise since I was at that Mexican fried bean restaurant."

The final mirror showed Robin Williams, rapid-fire. "Oh, look at this! Another mirror scene! Because apparently, ghosts can only appear in reflective surfaces accompanied by pipe organs! What is this, 'Haunted House: The Musical'? And the thunder! It's like Zeus is the show's producer—" he dropped into a booming Zeus impression, "'This scene needs more BOOM!'"

And then Sam appeared one final time, filling the glass.

"OH OH OHHHH! Okay, all you losers. Get a life and go do something useful. Didn't I entertain you for the last hour? You gonna sit there hoping for more? You should be thankful the writers didn't flash all these jokes like some strobe light, making you record and pause to read each of them... That would just be so lame and stupid... OH OH OHHHH!"

The mirrors went dark, one by one, like a marquee shutting down for the night.



Here's the thing about a good night — you never want it to end, and it always does, and the ending is what makes it good. Two people fell back in

love in a haunted mansion tonight. Two other people fell out of something that was never love to begin with. The house did the math, and the house is never wrong. Class dismissed, kids. Same time next book. OH. OH.

OHHHHHHHHH.

END OF BOOK TWO

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Derek Devon is the pen name of a first-time novelist who spent a long career in the corporate world before deciding the stories rattling around his head deserved better than PowerPoint. He is the author of the seventeen-book science fiction series *The Last Axiom* and the debut novel *A Letter Guide for Rebecca*.

Living With the Ghost of Sam is his love letter to the golden age of stand-up comedy, to old houses with opinions, and to everyone who ever lost someone and kept the conversation going.

He lives in Florida, where the thunder is frequent and, he insists, occasionally well-timed.

ALSO BY DEREK DEVON

The Last Axiom (Books 1–15)

A Letter Guide for Rebecca